



nearly 30,000 supporters from across the state. Yeddyurappa made light of former prime minister's absence at his swearing-in. "I idolise Atal Bihari Vajpayee, who managed 24 coalition partners. I will meet Gowda and discuss all the issues with him before taking any decisions," he said.

These issues include his open admiration for the Sangh Parivar. He regularly visits RSS headquarters, Keshavakrupa in Bangalore. In fact, Gujarat Chief Minister Narendra Modi's comments at the swearing-in that Karnataka will follow Gujarat's model came as a shock to JD(S). Though BJP President Rajnath Singh tried to make up for some of the damage by saying that what Modi meant was Gujarat's model of industrial development, Kumaraswamy has already pressed some warning buttons. "We are keen that their saffron agenda should not come to the fore. We have said our support is unconditional but we need to be kept in the loop," he said.

Gowda fears too much saffron will

overshadow the colour green that his party symbol is liberally sprinkled with. He is desperate to woo the minorities, especially the 10 per cent Muslim votes in the state. Gowda appointed Mirajuddin Patel as the first Muslim chief of the party's state unit two months ago and is now hoping to get him into the Cabinet too. Even the Congress, which is on a minority appeasement drive, says the BJP-JD(S) combo is an anathema for the state. "It is a black day for Karnataka and we oppose this unholy alliance," says the state unit chief of Congress Mallikharjuna Kharge. "This government won't last long," he has predicted.

Yeddyurappa, on the other hand, must also shake off the tendency to usher in a Lingayat raj. But on day one itself the people he appointed to his office raised the JD(S)'s predominantly Vokkaliga hackles. His new Principal Secretary V.P. Baligar and IGP, intelligence, Shankar Bidari, both belong to the Lingayat community. Baligar had been Yeddyurappa's choice for finance secretary when he had held the finance portfolio as deputy chief minister, but JD(S) had vetoed his suggestion.

GATEWAY: Advani, Rajnath celebrate entry into south with Yeddyurappa; Kumaraswamy (below)

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